

The Provincial Reorganization of Pakistan

**Constitutional, administrative, fiscal, demographic and
local-government considerations**

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Executive Summary

Pakistan's debate over provincial reorganization is a question of how political authority, public administration, fiscal resources and representation should be organized. The Constitution establishes a federal structure, four provinces in Article 1, local government under Article 140A, an intergovernmental fiscal framework under Article 160 and a demanding amendment procedure under Article 239.

A serious proposal must consider geography, administrative access, institutional capacity, fiscal sustainability, representation, transition costs and local government. Additional provinces are one possible institutional pathway among several; stronger local government and other decentralization arrangements can address some of the same objectives through different mechanisms.

1. The problem

Large and diverse administrative units can create questions about representation, institutional access, resource allocation and administrative distance. Territorial restructuring can also create new governments, institutions and transition costs.

2. Constitutional baseline

Article 1 identifies Balochistan, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Punjab and Sindh as provinces. Article 140A establishes the local-government obligation. Article 160 establishes the NFC framework. Article 239 establishes constitutional amendment procedure and the affected Provincial Assembly requirement where provincial limits are altered.

3. Demographic baseline

The 2023 Census reported Pakistan at 241.50 million. PBS reported Punjab at 127.69 million, Sindh at 55.70 million, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa at 40.86 million, Balochistan at 14.89 million and Islamabad Capital Territory at 2.36 million.

4. Arguments and reservations

Potential arguments include closer institutions, additional representation and geographically coherent administration. Reservations include setup costs, duplication, asset and liability division, fiscal uncertainty, boundary disputes, personnel arrangements and the possibility that local-government weakness is the underlying problem.

5. Provinces and local government

Article 140A makes local government a distinct constitutional mechanism. A serious reform study should compare territorial restructuring with deeper local devolution rather than assuming one mechanism solves every governance problem.

6. Fiscal architecture

Article 160 provides the National Finance Commission framework. A new province would require recurring fiscal arrangements and a transition budget covering institutions, personnel, buildings, systems and other one-time costs.

7. Administrative transition

A transition plan would need to address secretariat, departments, personnel, courts, police, prisons, service delivery, records, land, vehicles, contracts, assets and liabilities while protecting continuity of public services.

8. Evidence framework

Future PPRI scenario studies should publish population served, geographic area, access measures, institutional setup costs, recurring fiscal balance, revenue capacity, transfers, service coverage, representation, administrative capacity and legal requirements.

9. Conclusion

Pakistan's provincial structure is a legitimate subject for serious policy research. The appropriate research agenda is to measure administrative distance, representation, fiscal sustainability, institutional capacity and service delivery; compare territorial reform with local-government and other decentralization options; and publish constitutional and financial implications transparently.

Selected primary sources

Pakistan Bureau of Statistics — <https://www.pbs.gov.pk/census/>

Pakistan Code — <https://pakistancode.gov.pk/>

Ministry of Finance — https://www.finance.gov.pk/nfc_cons.html

Election Commission of Pakistan — <https://www.ecp.gov.pk/>

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